

The Lender-Ready Package Checklist

For owners refinancing a small apartment building in the next 6 to 24 months. Know how a lender sees your property before you call the bank.

A lender rebuilds your income before sizing your loan, then tests it two ways and takes the lower number. This checklist is the file that answers the underwriter's questions in the underwriter's order. You are not expected to have everything perfect. Tick what you can produce today. What is unclear, hard to explain, or missing is where preparation pays.

1. Financial package

- ☐ Trailing 12-month income and expense statement
- ☐ Prior two to three years of income and expense statements
- ☐ Projected income and expense for the next 12 months
- ☐ Rent roll: tenant, unit, rent, lease start and end
- ☐ Utility detail: water, sewer, electric, gas where applicable
- ☐ A written explanation for every expense spike or income gap
- ☐ Notes on owner-paid versus tenant-paid expenses

Lender lens: Is this income repeatable, and are these expenses believable?

2. Operations snapshot

- ☐ Vacancy explanation, facts not excuses
- ☐ Management structure: self-managed or third party
- ☐ Maintenance practice: reactive or preventative
- ☐ Known violations or issues, each with a resolution plan
- ☐ Lease expirations for the next 12 months, and the renewal plan

Lender lens: Does this property feel controlled or chaotic?

3. The property

- ☐ Unit mix and layout: bedrooms, baths, parking
- ☐ Capital improvements from the last three to five years
- ☐ Deferred maintenance notes, with plans and rough costs
- ☐ Current photos of units, common areas, mechanicals
- ☐ Inspection summaries, if any

Lender lens: Are there hidden future expenses we should worry about?

4. The owner's narrative

- ☐ What is stable
- ☐ What is improving, with the evidence
- ☐ What is temporary, and when it ends
- ☐ What you have already fixed
- ☐ Your loan maturity date and the 18-month timeline behind it

Lender lens: Do we trust this story?

The rule: most refinances do not fail on the rate. They fail when the owner discovers the lender's concerns too late to fix them. Start 18 months before maturity: run the lender's math at 18, fix and document at 12, assemble this package and shop lenders at 6, execute at 90 days with options in hand. Two or more sections above you cannot complete from your own records is the gap to close first.